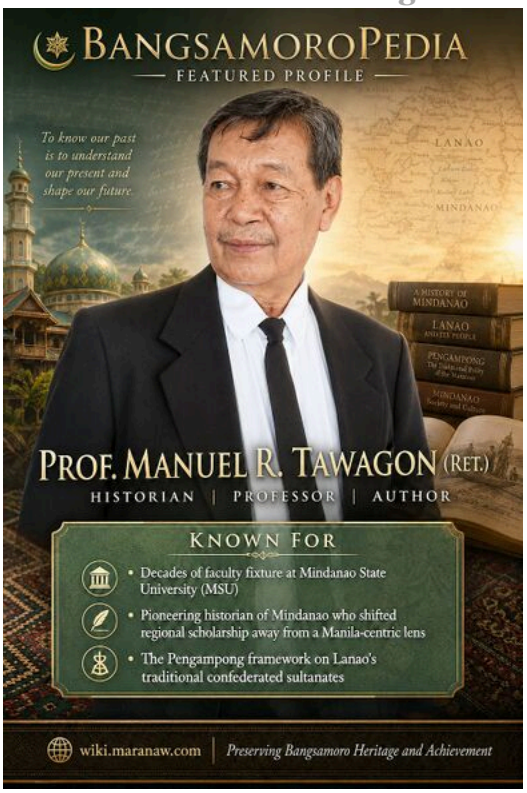
Manuel R. Tawagon

Prof. Manuel R. Tawagon (Ret.) is a Filipino historian, professor, and author whose name carries real weight whenever the conversation turns to Mindanao's past. He has spent his academic life specializing in Mindanao historiography, the socio-political structures of the Moro peoples, and the oral literature of the Maranao. For decades, he was a faculty fixture at Mindanao State University (MSU), and through that long tenure he helped push the study of Philippine history away from a Manila-centric, Eurocentric frame and toward something rooted firmly in the indigenous narratives of the southern Philippines.

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Prof. Manuel R. Tawagon



Born
Marawi City, Mindanao, Philippines

Occupation
Historian, professor, author

Alma Mater
Dansalan College (AB History, 1969); Silliman University (MA History, 1971)

Institution
Mindanao State University, Marawi City

Field
Mindanao historiography, Moro socio-political structures, Maranao oral literature

Notable Works
The Pengampong: A Historical Study of the Multiple Sultanates in the Philippines (1987); *Lake Lanao, National Power Corporation and the People of the Lake* (1984); *Spanish Perceptions of the Moros* (1989); *Roots of Mindanao Conflict: An Analysis* (2008)

Notability
Pioneering historian of Mindanao who shifted regional scholarship away from a Manila-centric lens

Known For
The Pengampong framework on Lanao's traditional confederated sultanates

Early Life and Education

Tawagon grew up in Mindanao, and that proximity to the region's ethno-linguistic and cultural diversity shaped the trajectory of his entire career. He came of age academically during the late 1960s, a period marked by rising political consciousness and ethnic identity movements across the southern Philippines, and that backdrop would later inform the historiographical questions he chose to pursue.

He completed his Bachelor of Arts in History at Dansalan College in Marawi City, graduating in 1969. From there he moved to Silliman University in Dumaguete City, where he earned his Master

of Arts in History in 1971. His master's thesis, titled "The Governor General in Spanish Philippines: An Administrative History," was an ambitious institutional study spanning 333 years of colonial administration, advised by Dr. Leslie Bauzon. Interestingly, this early work had nothing to do with Mindanao at all: it was only after he joined MSU that he turned his full attention to Mindanao historiography, a shift that would eventually produce his landmark study on the pengampong.

Academic Career and Institutional Contributions

The bulk of Tawagon's professional life was spent as a professor of history at Mindanao State University, principally at the main campus in Marawi City. There, he built a reputation not just as a researcher but as someone actively working to formalize localized historical research and train the next generation of Mindanawon scholars.

Gowing Memorial Research Center

Tawagon worked closely with the Gowing Memorial Research Center, which had originally been part of the Dansalan Foundation before being renamed in honor of the sociologist Peter Gowing. The center functioned as an early intellectual hub for Moro and Islamic studies in the region, and Tawagon made good use of its platforms to publish some of his foundational frameworks on the people of Lake Lanao.

Historiographical Methodology

At MSU, Tawagon became known for advocating a method he called "historiographical upstreaming." The idea is straightforward but demanding in practice: read colonial archives against the grain, then cross-reference what the European chroniclers wrote with local epics, genealogies (salsila), and oral traditions, in order to surface the indigenous agency that conventional colonial sources tend to erase or distort.

Major Works and Research Contributions

Tawagon's body of published work is widely cited across Southeast Asian anthropology, law, and history, and it generally falls into three areas: pre-colonial political systems, environmental histories, and conflict studies.

Traditional Governance: The Pengampong

His seminal 1987 monograph, *The Pengampong: A Historical Study of the Multiple Sultanates in the Philippines*, is arguably his most influential work. In it, he mapped out the complex traditional socio-political and territorial system of the Lanao region, showing how the pengampong (the four traditional principalities of Lanao) operated under a decentralized, confederated structure grounded in customary law (adat) and Islamic principles rather than a single centralized monarchy.

Conflict and Colonial Narratives

In *Spanish Perceptions of the Moros: A Historiographical Study* (1989), Tawagon took apart the colonial biases baked into Spanish-era texts, arguing that the language colonial writers used to describe Muslim populations was deliberately shaped to justify military campaigns against them.

Decades later, in *Roots of Mindanao Conflict: An Analysis* (2008), he turned to a more contemporary problem, offering a comprehensive look at the socio-economic, political, and historical structural imbalances that continue to drive instability in the region.

Environmental and Development Criticism

Tawagon was also ahead of his time on environmental history. His 1984 work, *Lake Lanao, National Power Corporation and the People of the Lake*, critically examined how state-led industrial projects, particularly NAPOCOR's hydroelectric infrastructure on Lake Lanao, disrupted the lake's ecology and marginalized the Maranao communities who had depended on it for generations.

Key Publications and Academic Impact

Taken together, Tawagon's scholarly output reads almost like a map of the major questions in Mindanao studies: traditional governance through *The Pengampong* (1987), development criticism through *Lake Lanao, National Power Corporation and the People of the Lake* (1984), colonial historiography through *Spanish Perceptions of the Moros* (1989), and contemporary conflict analysis through *Roots of Mindanao Conflict* (2008). Alongside all of this, he has also worked to document Maranao oral literature, ensuring that an entire oral tradition does not simply vanish from the historical record.

Cultural Significance and Legacy

Alongside figures like B.R. Rodil, Tawagon is considered one of the historians who helped democratize the writing of Philippine history.

His research pushed back against Manila-centric narratives, insisting that regional history is not a footnote to national history but essential to understanding it. Methodologically, by validating oral traditions and indigenous narratives as legitimate historical sources, he handed later generations of researchers tools they still rely on today. And in policy terms, his structural analysis of the roots of the Mindanao conflict remains a reference point for scholars and policymakers working on peacebuilding and the Bangsamoro region.

The Pengampong: Core Arguments

In *The Pengampong: A Historical Study of the Multiple Sultanates in the Philippines* (1987), Tawagon lays out a detailed structural and historical analysis of how the Maranao people of the Lanao region organized themselves politically before and alongside colonial contact.

Defining the Pengampong

Tawagon explains that the Lanao region has traditionally been divided into four socio-political principalities, or pengampong: Bayabao, Masiu, Unayan, and Baloi. Unlike the more centralized sultanates found in places like Sulu or Maguindanao, the pengampong system worked as a decentralized confederacy, with no single absolute monarch sitting at the top.

Dual Legal System

Governance within this system rested on two intertwined legal traditions: indigenous customary law (adat) and Islamic law (sharia).[1] Order was maintained through ancient, unwritten institutional codes known as taritib, and through consensus, or ijma, both passed down across generations.

Socio-Political Hierarchy

Each pengampong was further divided into sub-districts (soko) and village communities (inged). Leadership at every level was shared among co-equal titleholders, sultan, radia muda, and datus among them, who held power and authority collectively rather than answering up to a single center of command.

Cultural Resilience

Tawagon argues that this flexible, decentralized structure is precisely what allowed the Maranao people to successfully resist centuries of Spanish, American, and later Manila-centric assimilation efforts. Even without a unified state military to call their own, the confederate structure of the pengampong preserved a distinct cultural and territorial identity that has endured into the present.

Notes

[1] Tawagon, M. R. (1987). *The Pengampong: A Historical Study of the Multiple Sultanates in the Philippines.* Marawi City: Department of History, Mindanao State University.

Editorial Note

The following items from the submitted source material could not be independently corroborated through external verification and require submitter confirmation before this entry can be published:

1. Specific details of his MA thesis ("The Governor General in Spanish Philippines: An Administrative History") and the named thesis advisor, Dr. Leslie Bauzon. 2. The exact nature of his working relationship with the Gowing Memorial Research Center (role, title, or formal affiliation). 3. His current living/professional status (the source material does not specify, and no public record was found confirming whether he is still active, retired, or deceased).

Note: The four pengampong (Bayabao, Masiu, Unayan, Baloi) and the 1987 monograph *The Pengampong* are independently corroborated across multiple academic sources and require no further confirmation.

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